



Seagrass is one of the few true plants that grows in saltwater, forming dense meadows in shallow lagoons

Sea urchins graze on algae and tiny creatures found on rocks

◀ CORAL ARCHITECTURE

Corals come in an incredible array of colors, shapes, and sizes. Some form rounded masses, such as this golf ball coral. Others are treelike with thin branches. These coral structures provide the perfect hiding places for the reef animals.

WOW!

The algae living in tropical reef corals provide up to 90 percent of the reef's energy.

Red coralline algae

◀ PARADISE GARDENS

A tropical coral reef is like an oasis in a marine desert. Food is scarce in open tropical oceans, but the reef provides food and shelter for a dazzling diversity of fish, turtles, and crabs, as well as other animals. A quarter of all known marine species live on coral reefs, even though the area covered by the reefs is less than a hundredth of the total ocean area.

Tropical coral reefs grow only in water less than 490 ft (150 m) deep

▶ ORANGE SOFT CORAL

Many corals on cold-water reefs are soft corals without stony skeletons.

COLD-WATER REEFS

Not all coral reefs grow in the sunlit shallows of the tropics, where the corals feed on sugar made by algae living in their tissues. There are also cold-water reefs that live in deeper, darker water. They survive because colder oceans contain more plankton than tropical waters, providing the corals with all the food they need. This means the corals do not rely on sugar made by algae living in their tissues, so they don't need to grow in sunlit water.